

Lecture 11 – Mutable Variables

COSE212: Programming Languages

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2026 Fall

- Mutation makes it possible to **change the state** of a program by **updating the contents** of a data structure or a variable.
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 - **Mutable variables**

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- BFAE – FAE with Mutable Boxes
 - Evaluation with Memories

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 - **Mutable data structures**
 - **Mutable variables**
- **Mutable Data Structures** – Mutable Boxes
- BFAE – FAE with Mutable Boxes
 - Evaluation with Memories
- In this lecture, we will learn **Mutable Variables**
- MFAE – FAE **with Mutable Variables**
 - Concrete and Abstract Syntax
 - Interpreter and Natural Semantics

1. Mutable Variables

2. MFAE – FAE with Mutable Variables

Concrete Syntax

Abstract Syntax

3. Interpreter and Natural Semantics for MFAE

Evaluation with Memories

Interpreter and Natural Semantics

Mutable Variable

Identifier Lookup

Function Application

Assignment

4. Call-by-Value vs. Call-by-Reference

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A **mutable variable** is a variable whose value can be changed after its initialization.

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Let's define mutable variables in Scala:

```
// A mutable variable `x` of type `Int` with 1
var x: Int = 1
x + 2          // 1 + 2 == 3 : Int

// We can reassign a mutable variable `x`
x = 2          // x == 2
x + 2          // 2 + 2 == 4 : Int

// The function `f` is impure because it uses a mutable variable `y`
var y: Int = 1
def f(x: Int): Int = x + y
f(5)           // 5 + 1 == 6 : Int
y = 3
f(5)           // 5 + 3 == 8 : Int
```

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Now, let's extend FAE into MFAE to support **mutable variables**.

```
/* MFAE */  
var x = 5;  
x;           // 5  
x = 8;  
x           // 8
```

```
/* MFAE */  
var y = 1;  
var f = x => { x = x + y; x * x };  
f(5);        // (5 + 1) * (5 + 1) = 36  
y = 3;  
f(5)         // (5 + 3) * (5 + 3) = 64
```

For MFAE, we need to extend **expressions** of FAE with

- 1 **mutable variables** (`var`) rather than immutable variables (`val`)
(all variables, including parameters, are mutable in MFAE)
- 2 **assignment** (`=`)
(right-associative: e.g., $x = y = e$ is equivalent to $x = (y = e)$)
- 3 **sequence** of expressions

```
// expressions
<expr> ::= ...
        | "var" <id> "=" <expr> ";" <expr>
        | <id> "=" <expr>
        | <expr> ";" <expr>
```

For MFAE, we need to extend **expressions** of FAE with

- ① **mutable variables** (`var`) rather than immutable variables (`val`)
(all variables, including parameters, are mutable in MFAE)
- ② **assignment** (`=`)
(right-associative: e.g., $x = y = e$ is equivalent to $x = (y = e)$)
- ③ **sequence** of expressions

Let's define the **abstract syntax** of MFAE in BNF:

Expressions $\mathbb{E} \ni e ::= \dots$

<code>var x = e; e</code>	(Var)
<code>x = e</code>	(Assign)
<code>e; e</code>	(Seq)

```
enum Expr:
    ...
    // mutable variable definition
    case Var(name: String, init: Expr, body: Expr)
    // variable assignment
    case Assign(name: String, expr: Expr)
    // sequence
    case Seq(left: Expr, right: Expr)
```

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We can represent mutable variables by assigning different **addresses** to each variable in the environment and storing their values in the **memory**.

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Let's see how to evaluate the following MFAE expression:

```
/* MFAE */  
var x = 5;  
x;  
x = 8;  
x
```

*

$$\sigma = [$$

$$]$$
$$\mathbb{A} : a_0 \quad a_1 \quad a_2 \quad a_3 \quad \dots$$
$$M = \begin{array}{|c|c|c|c|c|} \hline & & & & \dots \\ \hline \end{array}$$

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Let's see how to evaluate the following MFAE expression:

```
/* MFAE */
var x = 5;
x;
x = 8;
x
```

$$\sigma = [$$

$$x \mapsto a_0$$

$$]$$

$\mathbb{A}$	:	a_0	a_1	a_2	a_3	$\dots$
M	=	5				$\dots$

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var x = 5;
x;           /* 5 */
x = 8;
x
```

$$\sigma = [\\ \quad x \mapsto a_0 \\]$$

$$\begin{array}{lcl} \mathbb{A} & : & a_0 \quad a_1 \quad a_2 \quad a_3 \quad \dots \\ M & = & \boxed{5} \quad \boxed{} \quad \boxed{} \quad \boxed{} \quad \boxed{\dots} \end{array}$$

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var x = 5;
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x            /* 8 */
```

$$\sigma = [\\ \quad x \mapsto a_0 \\]$$

$$\begin{array}{l} \mathbb{A} \\ M \end{array} : \begin{array}{cccc} a_0 & a_1 & a_2 & a_3 & \dots \end{array}$$

8				...
---	--	--	--	-----

Here is another MFAE expression:

```
/* MFAE */
var y = 1;
var f = x => {
  x = x + y;
  x * x
};
f(5);
y = 3;
f(5)
```

*

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$$]$$
$$\mathbb{A} : a_0 \quad a_1 \quad a_2 \quad a_3 \quad \dots$$
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$$]$$

$$\mathbb{A} : a_0 \quad a_1 \quad a_2 \quad a_3 \quad \dots$$

$$M = \begin{array}{|c|c|c|c|c|} \hline 1 & & & & \dots \\ \hline \end{array}$$

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$$\sigma = [$$

$$y \mapsto a_0$$

$$f \mapsto a_1$$

$$]$$

$$\mathbb{A} : a_0 \quad a_1 \quad a_2 \quad a_3 \quad \dots$$

$$M = \begin{array}{|c|c|c|c|c|} \hline 1 & v & & & \dots \\ \hline \end{array}$$

where $v = \langle \lambda x. (x = x + y; x * x), [y \mapsto a_0] \rangle$

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$$\sigma = [$$

$$y \mapsto a_0$$

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$$]$$

$$\mathbb{A} : a_0 \quad a_1 \quad a_2 \quad a_3 \quad \dots$$

$$M = \begin{array}{|c|c|c|c|c|} \hline 1 & v & 5 & & \dots \\ \hline \end{array}$$

where $v = \langle \lambda x. (x = x + y; x * x), [y \mapsto a_0] \rangle$

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var y = 1;
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  x = x + y; /* 5 + 1 */ *
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```

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$$\begin{array}{lcl} \mathbb{A} & : & a_0 \quad a_1 \quad a_2 \quad a_3 \quad \dots \\ M & = & \begin{array}{|c|c|c|c|c|} \hline 1 & v & 6 & & \dots \\ \hline \end{array} \end{array}$$

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  x * x      /* 6 * 6 */ *
};
f(5);
y = 3;
f(5)
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Here is another MFAE expression:

```
/* MFAE */
var y = 1;
var f = x => {
  x = x + y;
  x * x
};
f(5);           /* 36 */
y = 3;
f(5)
```

$$\sigma = [$$

$$y \mapsto a_0$$

$$f \mapsto a_1$$

$$]$$

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$$M = \begin{array}{|c|c|c|c|c|} \hline 1 & v & 6 & & \dots \\ \hline \end{array}$$

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$$x \mapsto a_3$$

$$]$$

$$\mathbb{A} : \begin{array}{cccccc} a_0 & a_1 & a_2 & a_3 & \dots \end{array}$$

$$M = \begin{array}{|c|c|c|c|c|} \hline 3 & v & 6 & 5 & \dots \\ \hline \end{array}$$

where $v = \langle \lambda x. (x = x + y; x * x), [y \mapsto a_0] \rangle$

Here is another MFAE expression:

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  x * x
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f(5);      /* 36 */
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```

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  x = x + y; /* 5 + 3 */
  x * x      /* 8 * 8 */ *
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f(5);        /* 36 */
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```

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where $v = \langle \lambda x. (x = x + y; x * x), [y \mapsto a_0] \rangle$

For MFAE, we need to 1) implement the **interpreter** with environments and **memories** by passing the updated memory in the result:

```
def interp(expr: Expr, env: Env, mem: Mem): (Value, Mem) = ???
```

```
type Env = Map[String, Addr]
type Addr = Int
type Mem = Map[Addr, Value]
```

```
enum Value:
  case NumV(n: BigInt)
  case CloV(p: String, b: Expr, e: Env)
```

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```

```
enum Value:
  case NumV(n: BigInt)
  case CloV(p: String, b: Expr, e: Env)
```

and 2) define the **natural semantics** with environments and **memories** by passing the updated memory in the result:

$$\sigma, M \vdash e \Rightarrow v, M$$

Environments	$\sigma \in \mathbb{X} \xrightarrow{\text{fin}} \mathbb{A}$	(Env)
Addresses	$a \in \mathbb{A}$	(Addr)
Memories	$M \in \mathbb{A} \xrightarrow{\text{fin}} \mathbb{V}$	(Mem)

```
def interp(expr: Expr, env: Env, mem: Mem): (Value, Mem) = expr match
...
case Var(name, init, body) =>
  val (iv, imem) = interp(init, env, mem)
  val addr = malloc(imem)
  interp(body, env + (name -> addr), imem + (addr -> iv))
```

$$\sigma, M \vdash e \Rightarrow v, M$$

$$\text{Var} \frac{a \notin \text{dom}(M_1) \quad \sigma, M \vdash e_1 \Rightarrow v_1, M_1 \quad \sigma[x \mapsto a], M_1[a \mapsto v_1] \vdash e_2 \Rightarrow v_2, M_2}{\sigma, M \vdash \text{var } x = e_1; e_2 \Rightarrow v_2, M_2}$$

We learned one way to implement malloc in the previous lecture:

```
def malloc(mem: Mem): Addr = mem.keySet.maxOption.fold(0)(_ + 1)
```

```
def interp(expr: Expr, env: Env, mem: Mem): (Value, Mem) = expr match
  ...
  case Id(name) => (mem(lookupId(env, name)), mem)

def lookupId(env: Env, name: String): Addr =
  env.getOrElse(name, error(s"free identifier: $name"))
```

$$\sigma, M \vdash e \Rightarrow v, M$$

$$\text{Id} \frac{x \in \text{dom}(\sigma)}{\sigma, M \vdash x \Rightarrow M(\sigma(x)), M}$$

```
def interp(expr: Expr, env: Env, mem: Mem): (Value, Mem) = expr match
...
case App(fun, arg) =>
  val (fv, fmem) = interp(fun, env, mem)
  fv match
    case CloV(param, body, fenv) =>
      val (av, amem) = interp(arg, env, fmem)
      val addr = malloc(amem)
      interp(body, fenv + (param -> addr), amem + (addr -> av))
    case _ =>
      error(s"not a function: ${fv.str}")
```

$$\boxed{\sigma, M \vdash e \Rightarrow v, M}$$

$$\text{App} \frac{\begin{array}{l} \sigma, M \vdash e_1 \Rightarrow \langle \lambda x. e_3, \sigma' \rangle, M_1 \quad \sigma, M_1 \vdash e_2 \Rightarrow v_2, M_2 \\ a \notin \text{dom}(M_2) \quad \sigma'[x \mapsto a], M_2[a \mapsto v_2] \vdash e_3 \Rightarrow v_3, M_3 \end{array}}{\sigma, M \vdash e_1(e_2) \Rightarrow v_3, M_3}$$

```
def interp(expr: Expr, env: Env, mem: Mem): (Value, Mem) = expr match
...
case Assign(name, expr) =>
  val (ev, emem) = interp(expr, env, mem)
  (ev, emem + (lookupId(env, name) -> ev))
```

$$\boxed{\sigma, M \vdash e \Rightarrow v, M}$$

$$\text{Assign} \frac{\sigma, M \vdash e \Rightarrow v, M' \quad x \in \text{dom}(\sigma)}{\sigma, M \vdash x = e \Rightarrow v, M'[\sigma(x) \mapsto v]}$$

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3. Interpreter and Natural Semantics for MFAE
 - Evaluation with Memories
 - Interpreter and Natural Semantics
 - Mutable Variable
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 - Function Application
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The current semantics of MFAE is based on the **call-by-value (CBV)** evaluation strategy, because the argument expression is always evaluated and the result **value** is passed to the parameter.

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However, we can define the semantics of MFAE in another way by using the **call-by-reference (CBR)** evaluation strategy instead; if the argument expression is an identifier, the parameter points to its **address**.

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CBV

$$\sigma = [$$
$$\begin{array}{l} f \mapsto a_0, \\ a \mapsto a_1, \\ b \mapsto a_2, \end{array}$$
$$]$$

a_0	a_1	a_2	a_3	a_4	a_5
$\langle \lambda \dots \rangle$	1	2			

/* MFAE */

```
var f = x => y => {  
  var t = x;  
  x = y;  
  y = t  
};  
var a = 1;  
var b = 2;  
f(a)(b); a; b
```

*

CBR

$$\sigma = [$$
$$\begin{array}{l} f \mapsto a_0, \\ a \mapsto a_1, \\ b \mapsto a_2, \end{array}$$
$$]$$

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$$y \mapsto a_4,$$

$$]$$

a_0	a_1	a_2	a_3	a_4	a_5
$\langle \lambda \dots \rangle$	1	2	1	2	

/ MFAE */*

```
var f = x => y => { *
  var t = x;
  x = y;
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var a = 1;
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f(a)(b); a; b
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CBR

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a_0	a_1	a_2	a_3
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$$x \mapsto a_3,$$

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$$t \mapsto a_5,$$

$$]$$

a_0	a_1	a_2	a_3	a_4	a_5
$\langle \lambda \dots \rangle$	1	2	1	2	1

/* MFAE */

```
var f = x => y => {
  var t = x;
  x = y;
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var a = 1;
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f(a)(b); a; b
```

*

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$$]$$

a_0	a_1	a_2	a_3	a_4	a_5
$\langle \lambda \dots \rangle$	1	2	2	2	1

/ MFAE */*

```
var f = x => y => {
  var t = x;
  x = y;
  y = t
};
var a = 1;
var b = 2;
f(a)(b); a; b
```

*

CBR

$$\sigma = [$$

$$x \mapsto a_1,$$

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a_0	a_1	a_2	a_3
$\langle \lambda \dots \rangle$	2	2	1

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a_0	a_1	a_2	a_3	a_4	a_5
$\langle \lambda \dots \rangle$	1	2	2	1	1

/ MFAE */*

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var f = x => y => {
  var t = x;
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a_0	a_1	a_2	a_3
$\langle \lambda \dots \rangle$	2	1	1

The current semantics of MFAE is based on the **call-by-value (CBV)** evaluation strategy, because the argument expression is always evaluated and the result **value** is passed to the parameter.

However, we can define the semantics of MFAE in another way by using the **call-by-reference (CBR)** evaluation strategy instead; if the argument expression is an identifier, the parameter points to its **address**.

CBV

$$\sigma = [$$

$$f \mapsto a_0,$$

$$a \mapsto a_1,$$

$$b \mapsto a_2,$$

$$]$$

a_0	a_1	a_2	a_3	a_4	a_5
$\langle \lambda \dots \rangle$	1	2	2	1	1

/ MFAE */*

```
var f = x => y => {
  var t = x;
  x = y;
  y = t
};
var a = 1;
var b = 2;
f(a)(b); a; b
```

*

CBR

$$\sigma = [$$

$$f \mapsto a_0,$$

$$a \mapsto a_1,$$

$$b \mapsto a_2,$$

$$]$$

a_0	a_1	a_2	a_3
$\langle \lambda \dots \rangle$	2	1	1

We can define the semantics of MFAE with the **call-by-reference (CBR)** evaluation strategy by adding the following case:

```
def interp(expr: Expr, env: Env, mem: Mem): (Value, Mem) = expr match
...
case App(fun, arg) =>
  val (fv, fmemb) = interp(fun, env, mem)
  fv match
    case CloV(param, body, fenv) => arg match
      case Id(name) =>
        val addr = lookupId(env, name)
        interp(body, fenv + (param -> addr), fmemb)
      case _ => ...
    case _ => error(s"not a function: ${fv.str}")
...

```

$$\text{App}_x \frac{\sigma, M \vdash e_1 \Rightarrow \langle \lambda x'. e_2, \sigma' \rangle, M_1 \quad x \in \text{dom}(\sigma) \quad \sigma'[x' \mapsto \sigma(x)], M_1 \vdash e_2 \Rightarrow v_2, M_2}{\sigma, M \vdash e_1(x) \Rightarrow v_2, M_2}$$

1. Mutable Variables
2. MFAE – FAE with Mutable Variables
 - Concrete Syntax
 - Abstract Syntax
3. Interpreter and Natural Semantics for MFAE
 - Evaluation with Memories
 - Interpreter and Natural Semantics
 - Mutable Variable
 - Identifier Lookup
 - Function Application
 - Assignment
4. Call-by-Value vs. Call-by-Reference

<https://github.com/ku-plrg-classroom/docs/tree/main/cose212/mfae>

- Please see above document on GitHub:
 - Implement `interp` function.
 - Implement `interpCBR` function.
- It is just an exercise, and you **don't need to submit** anything.
- However, some exam questions might be related to this exercise, so we **strongly recommend** solving it by yourself.

- Garbage Collection

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